

Medieval India

With the fall of the Gupta Empire in the 6th century, India entered a period in which the Hindu religion was revived, and Buddhism went into a rapid decline. From the 13th century, the first Muslim rulers established their empires in the region. Islamic kingdoms were founded in the north, while Hindu empires flourished in the south. The period ended with the beginning of the Mughal Empire in 1526.

After the breakup of the Gupta Empire (see pp.32–33), which had dominated much of India, new kingdoms came to power. In the late 10th century, the Cholas conquered rival kingdoms in the south. The Chola Empire grew rich through trade with Southeast Asia, and oversaw a golden age of art and architecture. Later, in the 14th century, the powerful new Vijayanagar Empire emerged in India's southwest and remained in control of the south for

three centuries. Both the Chola and the Vijayanagar built magnificent temples decorated with scenes from Hindu mythology.

In the north, the invasion of Muslim armies from Central Asia in the late 12th century led to the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate—the first Islamic empire in India—in 1206. It ruled large parts of India for 320 years, until its defeat by the Mughals (see pp.120–121).



RAZIA SULTANA

In 1236, Razia Sultana (1205–1240) became the first female ruler of the Delhi Sultanate. She was highly educated, skilled in martial arts, and rode elephants and horses.

Razia established schools and public libraries, and was known to be a strong but just ruler.

